

easy prospect

MARKET ENTRY STUDY

Granular Sulphur (Bright Yellow) – Germany

Demand, buyers, importers and distributors, quality requirements, prices, competition and market access for an Indian supplier

September 2026



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1. Executive summary

This study assesses the German market for bright yellow granular (formed) elemental sulphur from the perspective of an Indian manufacturer or exporter planning to enter Germany. It covers demand, buyer groups, importers and distributors, quality requirements, prices, competition, trade flows, distribution structures and market access requirements. Data reflect the situation as of September 2026.

• **Germany is a mature, mid-sized and structurally changing sulphur market.**

Domestic sulphur recovered from sour-gas processing fell from about 1.1 million tonnes in 2000 to about 284,000 tonnes in 2025. Refinery sulphur adds further volumes. Germany is still a net exporter of elemental sulphur (2023: exports of about 220,000 t versus imports of about 60,000 t), but the decline of domestic gas-based output is steadily reducing local supply.

• **The addressable import market for solid granular sulphur is niche but real.**

Large sulphuric acid producers mostly use liquid (molten) sulphur supplied by rail or barge from domestic and Benelux producers. Imported granular sulphur is mainly bought by traders and distributors, fertiliser and agricultural input companies, rubber and chemical processors and smaller acid or SO₂ producers with their own melting capacity. Recent import volumes are in the range of 50,000–70,000 t per year.

• **2026 is an extraordinary year for prices.** Following the US–Iran conflict and the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz, Middle East sulphur prices hit all-time records (ADNOC OSP USD 1,000/t fob in July and August 2026, KPC USD 865/t fob in September 2026, compared with about USD 520–530/t fob in February 2026). German delivered prices moved from about USD 750/t to USD 850/t between April and June 2026.

• **Critical constraint for an Indian supplier:** in July 2026 Indian refiners were effectively barred from exporting sulphur so that domestic fertiliser producers are supplied first. The measure was not formalised in a published decree but is widely applied in the market. Any export project must first confirm, in writing, that the specific material and origin may legally be exported (e.g. confirmation from DGFT/customs broker and the producing refinery).

• **Market access is comparatively simple on the customs side** (0 % duty for crude/unrefined sulphur CN 2503 00 10; 1.7 % for other sulphur CN 2503 00 90), but **REACH registration via an EU Only Representative, a German-language safety data sheet and a reliable certificate of analysis are mandatory in practice.** Formed sulphur (granules, prills, pastilles) is exempt from ADR/RID/ADN/IMDG dangerous goods rules under special provision 242.

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• **Recommendation:** enter through two or three established traders/distributors (e.g. Sojitz Solvadis, HELM, Brenntag, Biesterfeld) and selected agricultural repackers, using container shipments in 1 t FIBCs or 25/50 kg bags; position the product as a reliable non-Gulf origin with consistent bright- yellow quality ($\geq 99.5\%$ S, low ash/carbon, low As/Se), and prepare REACH, SDS and origin documentation before the first offer.

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2. Product definition and classification

Bright yellow granular sulphur is elemental sulphur recovered mainly from oil refining and sour-gas processing (Claus process) and solidified from the molten state into granules, prills or pastilles, typically 2–6 mm in size. Formed sulphur is bright yellow, odourless and has a bulk density of roughly 900–1,350 kg/m³. The bright yellow colour is commercially important because it signals low carbon/hydrocarbon contamination.

Item	Details
Chemical identity	Sulphur (S); CAS 7704-34-9; EC 231-722-6

Item	Details
Customs classification (EU CN)	2503 00 10 – crude or unrefined sulphur (recovered sulphur is usually declared here) 2503 00 90 – other sulphur (e.g. refined) Not 2802 00 00 (sublimed/precipitated/colloidal sulphur – a different, more refined product)
Typical commercial forms	Granules/prills/pastilles 2–6 mm; lumps; flakes; ground powder (for rubber and crop protection); sulphur-bentonite granules (fertiliser, approx. 90 % S)
Main end uses in Germany	Sulphuric acid and oleum, SO2/sulphites, fertilisers and soil conditioners, plant protection (fungicide), rubber vulcanisation, chemical intermediates, battery-materials value chain, beekeeping/wine cellar hygiene (small packs)

Tip: request a binding tariff information decision (vZTA) from German customs if the classification between 2503 00 10 and 2503 00 90 is uncertain, as the duty differs (0 % vs 1.7 %).

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3. Market size and demand in Germany

3.1 Domestic supply

Germany produces elemental sulphur from two main sources: sour-gas processing in Lower Saxony (plants in Großenkneten and Voigtei operated by ExxonMobil Production Deutschland) and refinery desulphurisation (e.g. PCK Raffinerie Schwedt, Yara Brunsbüttel and other refineries). Gas-based sulphur has fallen sharply because domestic natural gas production is declining.

Year	Sulphur from German natural gas processing (t)	Comment
2000	1,099,688	Peak era (late 1990s to mid-2000s)
2010	831,533	
2020	353,293	
2021	382,050	
2022	370,664	
2023	276,877	
2024	280,315	
2025	283,604	BEB 59 %, Mobil Erdgas-Erdöl 35 %, Vermilion 4 %, others

Source: BVEG (German oil and gas association) annual reports 2022–2025. Most of the gas-based sulphur is exported; part is processed domestically, e.g. into fertilisers.

3.2 Foreign trade (HS 2503)

Germany is a net exporter of elemental sulphur, but it also imports around 60,000 t per year, mainly from neighbouring EU countries. Direct imports from India are negligible so far, which means there are no established Indian supply relationships to compete against, but also no track record to build on.

Indicator (2023)	Volume (t)	Value (USD)	Implied unit value (USD/t)
Imports, total	59,863	15.6 million	≈ 260
from Poland	12,060	5.09 million	≈ 420

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Indicator (2023)	Volume (t)	Value (USD)	Implied unit value (USD/t)
from Netherlands	23,416	4.92 million	≈ 210
from Belgium	3,343	1.34 million	≈ 400

Indicator (2023)	Volume (t)	Value (USD)	Implied unit value (USD/t)
from Czech Republic	6,704	0.67 million	≈ 100
from Austria	1,259	0.65 million	≈ 515
from India	96	0.20 million	≈ 2,100 (small packs/speciality grades)
Exports, total	219,674	36.2 million	≈ 165
to Belgium / Netherlands / France	86,078 / 54,715 / 30,406	12.5 / 7.1 / 5.2 million	
to Sweden / Switzerland	22,167 / 13,204	4.9 / 2.6 million	

Source: UN Comtrade via WITS (HS 250310, reporter Germany, 2023). The large differences in unit values reflect different grades, packaging (bulk vs. bags) and contract structures.

3.3 Estimated consumption and addressable market

No official statistic on German sulphur consumption is published. A rough apparent-consumption estimate (analyst estimate) is: gas-based production of about 0.28 Mt, plus refinery sulphur (estimated at roughly 0.4–0.7 Mt, based on German crude throughput and typical sulphur recovery rates), plus imports of about 0.06 Mt, minus exports of about 0.22 Mt. This gives an apparent consumption of elemental sulphur in the order of 0.5–0.8 Mt per year. The large majority is used as liquid sulphur in integrated sulphuric acid plants.

For an Indian supplier of solid granular sulphur, the realistic addressable market is therefore the import segment (approx. 50,000–70,000 t/year) plus substitution potential where declining domestic gas sulphur, refinery closures or disrupted Gulf supply create gaps. At 2026 price levels (USD 650–1,000/t), this segment alone represents roughly USD 35–70 million per year.

3.4 Demand drivers

- **Sulphuric acid:** the largest outlet. Producers burning elemental sulphur include LANXESS (Leverkusen), Grillo (Frankfurt-Höchst) and BASF (Ludwigshafen). Metallurgical acid (e.g. from copper smelting) does not need elemental sulphur.
- **Agriculture:** German soils increasingly need sulphur fertilisation because industrial SO2 deposition has fallen sharply. Oilseed rape, legumes, cereals, grassland and brassica

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vegetables are key crops. Elemental sulphur (often with bentonite) is permitted in organic farming and listed in the FiBL input list.

- **Rubber and tyres:** sulphur is the standard vulcanising agent; the tyre and technical rubber industry buys ground, oil-treated or pre-dispersed sulphur, usually through specialised processors.
- **Chemicals and speciality uses:** SO₂ and sulphites (paper, food, water treatment), dimethyl sulphate, sulphonation, pigments, battery materials and pharmaceuticals.
- **Plant protection:** sulphur is an approved fungicide active substance (vines, fruit, hops, vegetables). Formulators need fine, very pure qualities.
- **Structural headwinds:** high energy costs, weak German chemical output and possible refinery closures reduce some demand but also reduce domestic supply.

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4. Potential large buyers

The following groups are the most relevant potential buyers of imported granular sulphur in Germany. Large integrated users usually buy liquid sulphur under annual contracts; solid granular imports are therefore mostly channelled through traders and distributors (see Chapter 5).

Buyer group	Examples in Germany	Relevance for granular imports
Sulphuric acid / oleum / SO2 producers burning sulphur	LANXESS (Leverkusen), Grillo-Werke/Grillo Chemicals (Frankfurt-Höchst, Duisburg), BASF (Ludwigshafen)	Medium – mainly liquid supply; granular as back-up or where melting capacity exists; high purity requirements
Fertiliser producers, blenders and agricultural repackers	Beckmann & Brehm; fertiliser trading houses (e.g. HELM); agricultural cooperatives and dealers	High – sulphur-bentonite granules and elemental sulphur in 25 kg bags and 1 t FIBCs; seasonal demand (autumn to spring)
Rubber chemical processors and tyre industry	LANXESS (Rhein Chemie additives), tyre and technical rubber producers	Medium – usually require ground/treated sulphur; raw granules can be sold to grinders
Plant protection formulators	Formulators of wettable sulphur fungicides	Low to medium – very strict purity (FAO specification), small volumes
Chemical distributors	Brenntag, Biesterfeld, Sojitz Solvadis	High – bundle demand of many small and medium users

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5. Key importers, traders and distributors

Only companies with their own website and direct contact data are listed. Contact data refer to the central switchboard and general e-mail addresses published by the companies (no personal buyer names). A first approach by phone and a short e-mail with specification, CoA, REACH status and indicative pricing is recommended.

5.1 Sulphur and commodity chemical traders

Company	Profile / relevance	Contact
Sojitz Solvadis GmbH Frankfurt am Main sojitz-solvadis.com	International marketing of sulphur, sulphuric acid, methanol and fertilisers is managed from the Frankfurt headquarters; listed as trader of formed sulphur. Most specialised sulphur trader in Germany – priority contact.	Tel. +49 69 57007-100 info@sojitz-solvadis.com
HELM AG Hamburg helmag.com	Family-owned trading house for chemicals, fertilisers and crop protection; one of the largest chemical traders worldwide. Relevant for bulk and agricultural sulphur.	Tel. +49 40 2375-0 info@helmag.com

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5.2 Full-line chemical distributors

Company	Profile / relevance	Contact
Brenntag GmbH Essen brenntag.com	German subsidiary of the global market leader in chemical distribution; 16 locations in Germany with filling, repacking and blending services. Channel to many small and medium industrial users.	Tel. +49 201 6496-0 infobrag@brenntag.de
Biesterfeld SE Hamburg biesterfeld.com	Distributor of plastics, rubber, basic and speciality chemicals, including industrial and agro chemicals and a dedicated rubber division (Biesterfeld Performance Rubber).	Tel. +49 40 32008-0 kontakt@biesterfeld.com

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5.3 Agricultural sulphur repackers and distributors

Company	Profile / relevance	Contact
Beckmann & Brehm GmbH Beckeln (Lower Saxony) beckhorn.de	Fertiliser company selling a 90 % elemental sulphur/bentonite granulate (2–6 mm, 25 kg bags) for arable, grassland and organic farming. Potential buyer of sulphur-bentonite or granular sulphur for its own brand.	Tel. +49 4244 9274-0 info@beckhorn.de

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5.4 Industrial end users (direct buyers)

Company	Profile / relevance	Contact
Grillo-Werke AG Duisburg / Frankfurt-Höchst grillo.de Supplier page: grillo.de/lieferanten	Produces sulphur chemicals (SO ₂ , SO ₃ , oleum, sulphuric acid 96/98 %, sulphites, dimethyl sulphate) at Industriepark Höchst and recycles spent acid in Duisburg.	Tel. +49 203 5557-0 info@grillo.de
LANXESS Deutschland GmbH Cologne / Leverkusen lanxess.com	Operates one of Europe's most modern sulphuric acid plants in Leverkusen (incl. food-grade acid made from elemental sulphur); rubber additives via Rhein Chemie.	Tel. +49 221 8885-0 General e-mail: not published – use switchboard
BASF SE Ludwigshafen basf.com	Largest integrated chemical site in Europe; produces sulphuric acid including semi conductor grade. Purchasing via central procurement; long qualification cycles.	Tel. +49 621 60-0 General e-mail: not published – use switchboard

Buyer names are not listed for data-protection reasons. Several of the companies publish product-manager contacts on their websites. Global traders headquartered in Switzerland (e.g. Ameropa) also supply the German market and can be approached in a second step.

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6. Quality requirements

German buyers expect a consistent, well-documented quality with a certificate of analysis (CoA) for every lot, ideally confirmed by an independent inspection company (e.g. SGS, Intertek, Bureau Veritas) at loading. The following values reflect typical international specifications for bright yellow formed sulphur; final limits are agreed in each contract.

Parameter	Typical requirement	Why it matters
Purity (S, dry basis)	≥ 99.5 %; premium ≥ 99.9 %	Acid plant efficiency; fertiliser and speciality uses
Colour	Bright yellow	Indicator of low carbon/hydrocarbon content
Ash	≤ 0.05 % (often ≤ 0.02–0.04 %)	Deposits in burners and catalysts
Carbon / organics (bitumen)	≤ 0.03–0.05 %	Dark acid, catalyst fouling
Acidity (as H2SO4)	≤ 0.01 %	Corrosion of storage and melting equipment
Moisture	≤ 0.5 % (bagged often ≤ 0.2 %)	Corrosion, weight disputes
Arsenic / selenium / tellurium	Typically ≤ 1 ppm each (application-specific)	Food/feed/pharma chains, catalyst poisons, fertiliser heavy-metal limits
Hydrogen sulphide	Degassed (low residual H2S)	Safety in storage and transport
Granulometry	2–6 mm; low fines (< 1 mm typically ≤ 1–2 %)	Dust, explosion risk, spreading behaviour
Friability / hardness	Low friability (formed-sulphur standards)	Fines generation during handling

Example: a German retailer of small-pack granular sulphur specifies ash ≤ 0.04 %, acidity ≤ 0.007 %, bitumen ≤ 0.015 %, moisture ≤ 0.2 % and 90 % of granules between 0.5 and 3.2 mm – illustrating that German customers expect detailed specification sheets.

6.1 Application-specific requirements

- **Fertiliser use:** if sold as an EU fertilising product (CE-marked under Regulation (EU) 2019/1009), the product must meet contaminant limits and component-material rules; alternatively it can be

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marketed as a national fertiliser type under the German Fertiliser Ordinance (DüMV). Sulphur-bentonite products need declared S content and disintegration behaviour.

- **Organic farming:** elemental sulphur is an authorised input; listing in the FiBL input list for Germany is a strong sales argument for agricultural distributors.
- **Plant protection:** technical sulphur for fungicide formulation must comply with the relevant FAO specification and the EU active-substance approval; the finished product requires authorisation by the German authority BVL.
- **Rubber:** tight particle-size distribution, low ash and low acidity; often oil-treated or insoluble sulphur – usually processed by specialised grinders.

6.2 Packaging and documentation

- Bulk (break-bulk vessel) for large volumes; 1 t FIBCs (jumbo bags) with liner, UV-stabilised; 25 kg or 50 kg PP bags on pallets; 20 ft containers typically carry about 24–26 t.
- Documents: CoA per lot, inspection certificate, certificate of origin, packing list, REACH registration number, safety data sheet in German, and for agricultural products a fertiliser label in German.

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7. Price level

Sulphur prices are set internationally, mainly by the monthly contract prices of Middle East producers (ADNOC, QatarEnergy, KPC) and by spot deals in China, India, Brazil and North Africa. European prices follow with a lag and a logistics premium. 2026 is an exceptional year because of the Gulf supply disruption.

Reference	Price	Date
ADNOC OSP (fob Ruwais, Indian subcontinent)	USD 530/t	February 2026
ADNOC OSP	USD 760/t	May 2026
ADNOC OSP (record at that time)	USD 860/t	June 2026
ADNOC OSP	USD 1,000/t (rolled over in August)	July/August 2026
QatarEnergy QSP (fob)	USD 890/t	July/August 2026
KPC KSP (fob Kuwait)	USD 865/t (unchanged from August)	September 2026
Freight Gulf–China (30–35 kt)	USD 145–160/t, plus war-risk premiums	Late August 2026
Sulphur Germany (delivered, indicative)	USD 750/t → USD 850/t	April → June 2026
Sulphur Europe (index, indicative)	USD 640/t	August 2026
Sulphur Europe (index, indicative)	USD 316/t	January 2026
German import unit value (all origins)	≈ USD 260/t	2023 (pre-crisis reference)
China sulphur futures	≈ CNY 7,750/t; –16 % in one month, +194 % y/y	22 September 2026

Sources: Argus Media, Procurement Resource, IMARC, Intratec, Trading Economics, UN Comtrade. Index values are indicative and vary by methodology.

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7.1 Price structure for an Indian supplier (illustrative)

A CIF/CFR Hamburg, Rotterdam or Antwerp price for containerised bagged sulphur is built up as follows: FOB India price (linked to Middle East and India netbacks) + bagging (FIBC or 25 kg bags) + container freight India–North Europe (route via Suez/Red Sea or Cape of Good Hope, currently volatile) + insurance + EU customs duty (0 % or 1.7 %) + port handling and customs clearance + inland transport (truck, rail or Rhine barge). Bagged sulphur for agriculture or small industrial users typically achieves a premium of several hundred euros per tonne over bulk sulphur because of packaging, handling and smaller lot sizes.

Outlook: the September 2026 decline in Chinese futures suggests that the peak may have passed, but prices will remain far above pre-crisis levels as long as Gulf exports are constrained. Offers should be indexed (e.g. to a published Middle East or Northwest Europe benchmark) or have short validity (7–14 days).

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8. Competition

8.1 Domestic producers

- **Natural gas processing:** BEB Erdgas und Erdöl, Mobil Erdgas-Erdöl (both operated by ExxonMobil Production Deutschland) and Vermilion; combined output about 284,000 t in 2025, mainly liquid and exported.
- **Refineries:** e.g. PCK Raffinerie Schwedt (listed as producer of formed sulphur) and other German refineries; Yara Brunsbüttel also produces sulphur.

8.2 European competitors

- **Poland:** Grupa Azoty Siarkopol produces granulated sulphur; Poland was the largest supplier to Germany by value in 2023.
- **Netherlands and Belgium:** refinery sulphur from the Rotterdam–Antwerp cluster; largest supplier to Germany by volume (Netherlands).
- **Czech Republic, Austria, Italy, Spain, France:** smaller volumes of refinery sulphur into southern and eastern Germany.

8.3 Non-EU competitors

Origin	EU imports 2024 (t)	Comment
Kazakhstan	282,559	Largest non-EU supplier; rail and sea via Black Sea/Baltic
Turkey	76,744	Export ban on sulphur from 7 April 2026 through Q2–Q3 2026
Libya	59,931	
United Kingdom	53,133	Refinery sulphur
United States	43,136	
United Arab Emirates	26,702	Supply severely disrupted by the Hormuz closure in 2026
Serbia	30,736	
India	985	Very small; mainly speciality and bagged material
Total extra-EU	599,318	Value USD 86.3 million

Source: UN Comtrade via WITS (HS 250310, reporter EU, 2024). Russia had extended its ban on industrial sulphur exports until 30 June 2026; imports of Russian material into the EU are in any case largely avoided by buyers.

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8.4 Indian competitors

India’s main sulphur exporter is Reliance Industries (Jamnagar refinery complex, loading at Bedi port). In 2024 more than 90 % of Indian exports went to China. Other Indian refiners and several traders and sulphur-bentonite producers also export. An Indian supplier therefore competes both with Indian peers and with established European supply chains.

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9. Main buyer countries and distribution structures

9.1 Global trade flows

Global trade in sulphur (HS 2503) reached USD 4.67 billion in 2024. The largest exporters were the United Arab Emirates (USD 1.1 billion), Qatar (USD 569 million) and Saudi Arabia (USD 504 million); the largest importers were Morocco (USD 1.13 billion), China (USD 915 million) and Indonesia (USD 443 million). In volume terms (2023), China (8.8 Mt), Morocco (6.5 Mt), Indonesia (2.7 Mt), the DR Congo (2.7 Mt) and Brazil (2.4 Mt) were the largest importers – driven by phosphate fertilisers, metal leaching (copper, cobalt, nickel) and battery materials.

Within Europe, Germany’s own export customers are Belgium, the Netherlands, France, Sweden and Switzerland – i.e. Germany is part of a tightly integrated Northwest European sulphur market in which liquid sulphur moves between refineries and acid plants along the Rhine and via the ARA ports.

9.2 Distribution structure in Germany

Channel	Typical form and lot size	Logistics
Producer → large acid/chemical plant (direct contract)	Liquid sulphur; thousands of tonnes per month; annual contracts	Rail tank cars, barges on Rhine/Elbe, pipelines within chemical parks
Importer/trader → industrial users	Solid granular, bulk or FIBC; 500–5,000 t lots	Bulk vessels to ARA/Hamburg, then barge, rail or truck; bonded warehouses
Distributor → small and medium users	FIBC and 25 kg bags; 1–100 t	Distributor warehouses, truck delivery
Agricultural wholesale → farmers	Sulphur-bentonite or elemental granules, 25 kg and 500–1,000 kg bags	Cooperatives, agricultural dealers, seasonal stocking
Speciality/small packs	0.5–25 kg	Webshops, beekeeping, garden and wine supplies

Main ports of entry are Hamburg, Rotterdam and Antwerp; Duisburg (Europe’s largest inland port) is the hub for the Rhine-Ruhr chemical cluster. Container imports from India typically arrive at Hamburg or Rotterdam.

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10. Market access requirements

10.1 Customs and trade policy

- EU Common Customs Tariff: CN 2503 00 10 (crude or unrefined sulphur) duty-free; CN 2503 00 90 (other sulphur) 1.7 % erga omnes. Import VAT in Germany 19 % (recoverable for VAT-registered importers).
- EU–India Free Trade Agreement: negotiations were concluded on 27 January 2026; the Commission proposed signature to the Council in September 2026. The agreement is not yet in force and does not change current import conditions.
- CBAM: sulphur (HS 2503) is not covered by the EU Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism in its current scope; some downstream fertilisers are.
- Origin and sanctions compliance: German buyers will require a certificate of origin and assurance that the material is not of sanctioned origin (e.g. Russia, Iran) and has not been blended with such material.

10.2 Chemicals regulation (REACH and CLP)

- **REACH:** sulphur is registered under REACH. A non-EU manufacturer cannot register itself; it must appoint an Only Representative (OR) in the EU, or the EU importer must hold its own registration.

Without a valid registration covering the import tonnage, the product cannot be placed on the EU market.

- **CLP:** sulphur is classified as skin irritant (Skin Irrit. 2, H315); labels on bags and FIBCs must be in German.
- **Safety data sheet:** an SDS compliant with REACH Annex II in German is required for professional customers.

10.3 Transport and storage

- Dangerous goods: sulphur formed to a specific shape (prills, granules, pellets, pastilles, flakes) is not subject to ADR, RID, ADN, IMDG or ICAO rules under special provision 242. Lump or crushed sulphur remains UN 1350, class 4.1.
- Bulk sea transport: formed solid sulphur is carried under the IMSBC Code schedule "Sulphur (formed, solid)".
- Storage and handling: sulphur dust is combustible and can form explosive atmospheres; German customers apply explosion-protection rules (ATEX, TRGS) – low fines content is therefore a commercial advantage.

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10.4 Requirements by supplier origin (overview)

Supplier origin	Customs	REACH	Other
EU (e.g. Poland, Netherlands)	No duty, intra-EU trade	Own registration as EU manufacturer	No import formalities
Non-EU Europe (e.g. UK, Serbia, Norway)	Duty-free or reduced under FTAs	OR or EU importer registration	Proof of preferential origin
Non-European (e.g. India)	0 % (2503 00 10) or 1.7 % (2503 00 90); EU-India FTA not yet in force	OR mandatory unless importer registers	Origin, sanctions compliance, longer lead times

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11. Specific considerations for an Indian supplier

11.1 Current Indian export situation

Following the disruption of Gulf supplies, India – itself a net importer of about 2.25 Mt of sulphur in 2025, 84 % from the Middle East – asked refiners to prioritise domestic supply. In July 2026 exports were effectively suspended; the measure was not published as a formal decree, but Indian refiners were understood to be unable to ship sulphur abroad until further notice. Before any commercial approach to German buyers, the supplier must clarify whether its material (refinery sulphur, sulphur from other sources, or processed products such as sulphur-bentonite or ground sulphur) may currently be exported, and when normal export conditions are expected to return.

11.2 Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, threats

Strengths	Weaknesses
Large refinery base, consistent bright-yellow quality possible Non-Gulf origin, independent of the Strait of Hormuz Competitive production and bagging costs Experience in sulphur-bentonite and speciality grades	No track record in Germany; very small current export volumes to the EU Longer transit times than EU and Kazakh suppliers REACH OR and German-language documentation still to be set up Current export restrictions in India
Opportunities	Threats
Declining German gas sulphur output Buyers seeking diversification after the 2026 supply shock Growing demand for sulphur fertilisers and organic inputs EU-India FTA as positive framework in the medium term	Price volatility – risk of losses on fixed-price contracts Resumption of Gulf exports leading to sharp price decline Strong position of EU refinery and Kazakh suppliers Reputation risk: sulphur trade is a frequent target of fraudulent offers, so German buyers are cautious with unknown suppliers

11.3 Building trust with German buyers

- Present verifiable company data (registration, GST/IEC, audited financials, references, plant or supply-source photos) and a professional English/German website.
- Offer samples with CoA and independent analysis; accept inspection at loading by a buyer-nominated company.
- Use standard payment terms (documentary letter of credit or CAD for first orders) and Incoterms 2020 (CFR/CIF ARA or Hamburg; FCA/DAP for smaller lots).

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- Hold ISO 9001 (and ideally ISO 14001) certification; state the carbon footprint if available, as German buyers increasingly ask for product carbon footprints.
- Use the Indo-German Chamber of Commerce and industry events (e.g. CRU Sulphur and Sulphuric Acid conferences, fertiliser and chemical trade fairs) for introductions.

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12. Market entry strategy and recommendations

Step	Action	Timing
1	Confirm legal export eligibility from India (current export suspension) and secure a reliable, traceable supply source.	Immediately
2	Appoint an EU REACH Only R epresentative; prepare German SDS, German labels, specification sheet and CoA template.	1–3 months
3	Define product range: bulk/FIBC granular sulphur (≥ 99.5 %), bagged 25 kg, and possibly s ulphur-benton ite 90 % for agriculture.	1–2 months
4	Approach priority traders and distributors (Sojitz Solvadis, HELM, Brenntag, Biesterfeld) and agricultural repackers (e.g. Beckmann & Brehm) with samples and indexed indicative offers.	2–4 months

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Step	Action	Timing
5	Supply trial lots (1–3 containers) to prove quality, packaging and on-time delivery; accept independent inspection.	3–6 months
6	Develop frame contracts (quarterly or semi-annual, index-linked) and consider a consignment or buffer stock in Hamburg or Rotterdam for the agricultural season.	6–12 months
7	In the medium term, approach industrial end users (acid/SO2 producers) and use the EU– India FTA once in force.	12–24 months

Overall assessment: the German market is attractive for a reliable, well-documented supplier of bright yellow granular sulphur, particularly in the agricultural and distributor segments, where bagged material and consistent quality command a premium. Success depends less on price alone than on compliance (REACH, SDS), traceable origin, quality consistency and the ability to supply despite the current Indian export restrictions.

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Disclaimer: This study is based on publicly available information as of September 2026. Market data, prices, regulations and contact details can change; they should be verified before commercial decisions are taken. No legal or customs advice.